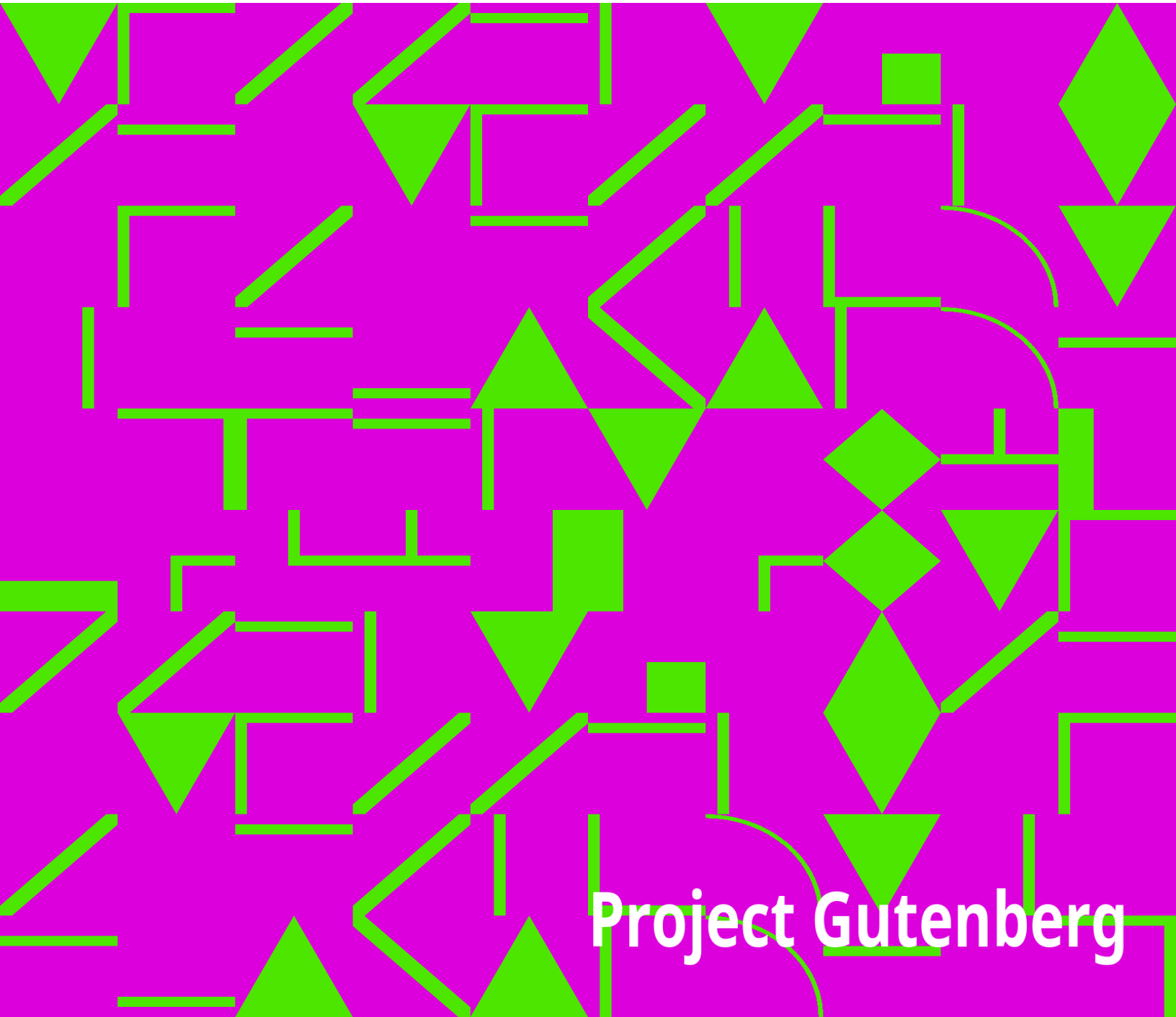


Sonnets, and Sonnets on English Dramatic Poets (1590-1650)

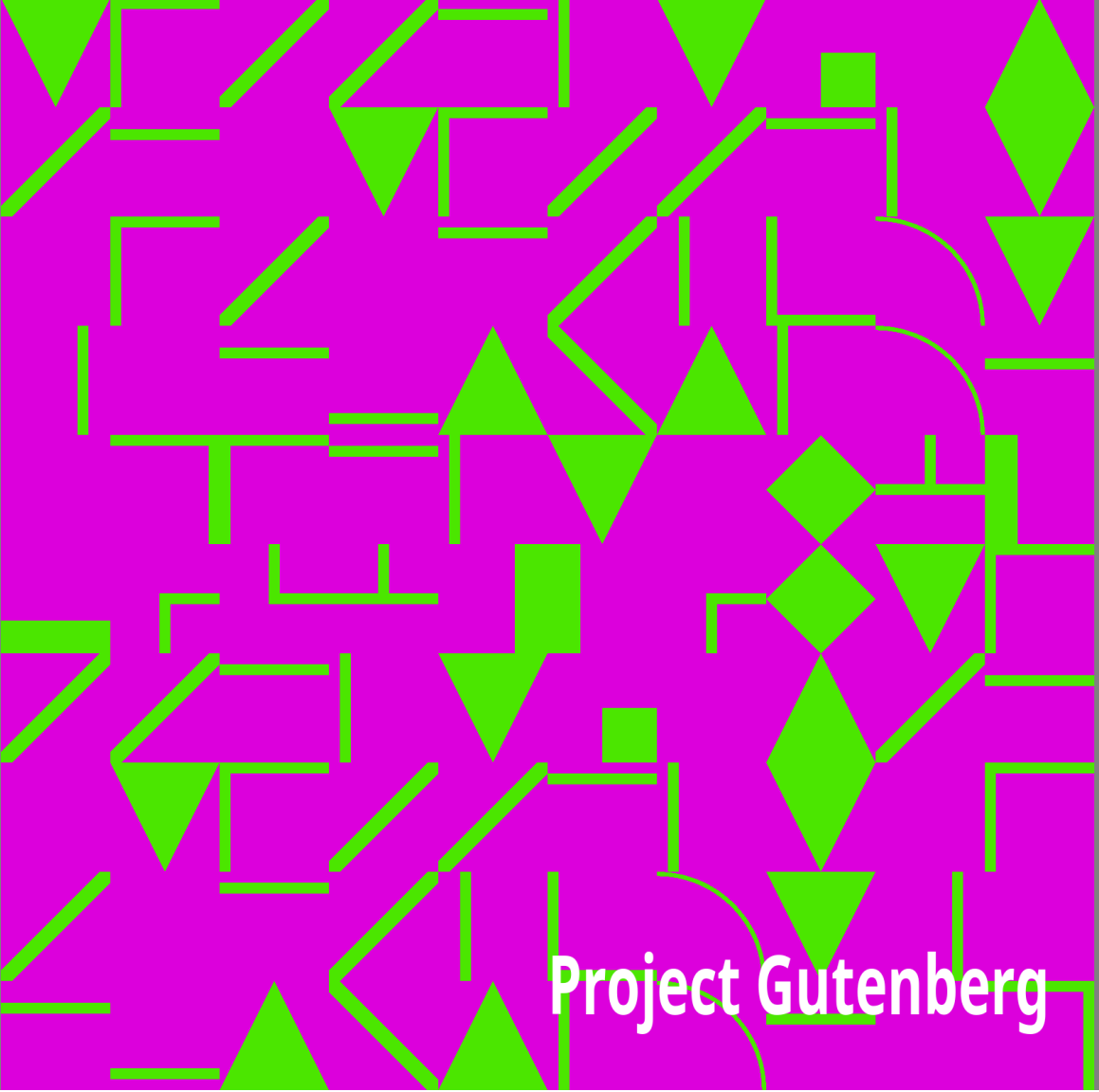
Algernon Charles Swinburne



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Sonnets, and Sonnets on English Dramatic Poets (1590-1650)

Algernon Charles Swinburne



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SONNETS ON ENGLISH DRAMATIC POETS (1590-1650) ***

Sonnets

Sonnets on English Dramatic Poets (1590-1650)

By Algernon Charles Swinburne

Taken from

**The Collected Poetical Works of Algernon Charles Swinburne,
Vol V.**

SWINBURNE'S POETICAL WORKS

- I. POEMS AND BALLADS (First Series).
- II. SONGS BEFORE SUNRISE, and SONGS OF TWO NATIONS.
- III. POEMS AND BALLADS (Second and Third Series), and
SONGS OF THE SPRINGTIDES.
- IV. TRISTRAM OF LYONESSE, THE TALE OF BALEN, ATALANTA IN
CALYDON, ERECHTHEUS.
- V. STUDIES IN SONG, A CENTURY OF ROUNDELS, SONNETS ON
ENGLISH DRAMATIC POETS, THE HEPTALOGIA, ETC.
- VI. A MIDSUMMER HOLIDAY, ASTROPHEL, A CHANNEL PASSAGE
AND OTHER POEMS.

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SONNETS



HOPE AND FEAR

Beneath the shadow of dawn's aerial cope,
 With eyes enkindled as the sun's own
 sphere,
 Hope from the front of youth in godlike
 cheer
Looks Godward, past the shades where blind
men grope
Round the dark door that prayers nor dreams can
ope,
 And makes for joy the very darkness dear
 That gives her wide wings play; nor dreams
 that fear
At noon may rise and pierce the heart of hope.
Then, when the soul leaves off to dream and
yearn,
May truth first purge her eyesight to discern
 What once being known leaves time no
 power to appal;
Till youth at last, ere yet youth be not, learn
 The kind wise word that falls from years
 that fall—
 "Hope thou not much, and fear thou not at
 all."

AFTER SUNSET

"Si quis piorum Manibus locus."

I

Straight from the sun's grave in the deep clear
west

A sweet strong wind blows, glad of life: and

I,

Under the soft keen stardawn whence the
sky

Takes life renewed, and all night's godlike breast
Palpitates, gradually revealed at rest

By growth and change of ardours felt on
high,

Make onward, till the last flame fall and die
And all the world by night's broad hand lie blest.

Haply, meseems, as from that edge of death,
Whereon the day lies dark, a brightening breath

Blows more of benediction than the morn,
So from the graves whereon grief gazing saith
That half our heart of life there lies forlorn
May light or breath at least of hope be born.

II

The wind was soft before the sunset fled:

Now, while the cloud-enshrouded corpse of
day

Is lowered along a red funereal way

Down to the dark that knows not white from red,
A clear sheer breeze against the night makes
head,

Serene, but sure of life as ere a ray
Springs, or the dusk of dawn knows red
from grey,
Being as a soul that knows not quick from dead.
From far beyond the sunset, far above,
Full toward the starry soundless east it
blows
Bright as a child's breath breathing on a
rose,
Smooth to the sense as plume of any dove;
Till more and more as darkness grows and
glows
Silence and night seem likest life and love.

III

If light of life outlive the set of sun
That men call death and end of all things,
then
How should not that which life held best for
men
And proved most precious, though it seem
undone
By force of death and woful victory won,
Be first and surest of revival, when
Death shall bow down to life arisen again?
So shall the soul seen be the self-same one
That looked and spake with even such lips and
eyes
As love shall doubt not then to recognise,
And all bright thoughts and smiles of all
time past
Revive, transfigured, but in spirit and sense
None other than we knew, for evidence
That love's last mortal word was not his last.

A STUDY FROM MEMORY

If that be yet a living soul which here
Seemed brighter for the growth of
numbered springs
And clothed by Time and Pain with goodlier
things

Each year it saw fulfilled a fresh fleet year,
Death can have changed not aught that made it
dear;

Half humorous goodness, grave-eyed mirth
on wings
Bright-balanced, blither-voiced than quiring
strings;

Most radiant patience, crowned with conquering
cheer;

A spirit inviolable that smiled and sang
By might of nature and heroic need
More sweet and strong than loftiest dream
or deed;

A song that shone, a light whence music rang
High as the sunniest heights of kindest
thought;
All these must be, or all she was be nought.

TO DR. JOHN BROWN

Beyond the north wind lay the land of old
 Where men dwelt blithe and blameless,
 clothed and fed
 With joy's bright raiment and with love's
 sweet bread,
The whitest flock of earth's maternal fold.
None there might wear about his brows enrolled
 A light of lovelier fame than rings your
 head,
 Whose lovesome love of children and the
 dead
All men give thanks for: I far off behold
A dear dead hand that links us, and a light
The blithest and benignest of the night,
 The night of death's sweet sleep, wherein
 may be
A star to show your spirit in present sight
 Some happier island in the Elysian sea
 Where Rab may lick the hand of Marjorie.

March 1882.

TO WILLIAM BELL SCOTT

The larks are loud above our leagues of whin
Now the sun's perfume fills their glorious
gold
With odour like the colour: all the wold
Is only light and song and wind wherein
These twain are blent in one with shining din.
And now your gift, a giver's kingly-souled,
Dear old fast friend whose honours grow
not old,
Bids memory's note as loud and sweet begin.
Though all but we from life be now gone forth
Of that bright household in our joyous north
Where I, scarce clear of boyhood just at end,
First met your hand; yet under life's clear
dome,
Now seventy strenuous years have crowned my
friend,
Shines no less bright his full-sheaved
harvest-home.

April 20, 1882.

A DEATH ON EASTER DAY

The strong spring sun rejoicingly may rise,
Rise and make revel, as of old men said,
Like dancing hearts of lovers newly wed:
A light more bright than ever bathed the skies
Departs for all time out of all men's eyes.
The crowns that girt last night a living head
Shine only now, though deathless, on the
dead:
Art that mocks death, and Song that never dies.
Albeit the bright sweet mothlike wings be furled,
Hope sees, past all division and defection,
And higher than swims the mist of
human breath,
The soul most radiant once in all the world
Requicken'd to regenerate resurrection
Out of the likeness of the shadow of
death.

April 1882.

ON THE DEATHS OF THOMAS CARLYLE AND GEORGE ELIOT

Two souls diverse out of our human sight
 Pass, followed one with love and each with
 wonder:
 The stormy sophist with his mouth of
 thunder,
Clothed with loud words and mantled in the
might
Of darkness and magnificence of night;
 And one whose eye could smite the night in
 sunder,
 Searching if light or no light were
 thereunder,
And found in love of loving-kindness light.
Duty divine and Thought with eyes of fire
Still following Righteousness with deep desire
 Shone sole and stern before her and above,
Sure stars and sole to steer by; but more sweet
Shone lower the loveliest lamp for earthly feet,
 The light of little children, and their love.

AFTER LOOKING INTO CARLYLE'S REMINISCENCES

I

Three men lived yet when this dead man was
young
 Whose names and words endure for ever:
 one
 Whose eyes grew dim with straining toward
 the sun,
And his wings weakened, and his angel's tongue
Lost half the sweetest song was ever sung,
 But like the strain half uttered earth hears
 none,
 Nor shall man hear till all men's songs are
 done:
One whose clear spirit like an eagle hung
Between the mountains hallowed by his love
And the sky stainless as his soul above:
 And one the sweetest heart that ever spake
The brightest words wherein sweet wisdom
smiled.
These deathless names by this dead snake defiled
 Bid memory spit upon him for their sake.

II

Sweet heart, forgive me for thine own sweet
sake,
 Whose kind blithe soul such seas of sorrow
 swam,
 And for my love's sake, powerless as I am
For love to praise thee, or like thee to make

Music of mirth where hearts less pure would
break,

Less pure than thine, our life-unspotted
Lamb.

Things hatefulest thou hadst not heart to
damn,

Nor wouldst have set thine heel on this dead
snake.

Let worms consume its memory with its tongue,
The fang that stabbed fair Truth, the lip that
stung

Men's memories uncorroded with its breath.

Forgive me, that with bitter words like his
I mix the gentlest English name that is,

The tenderest held of all that know not
death.

A LAST LOOK

Sick of self-love, Malvolio, like an owl
That hoots the sun risen where starlight
sank,
With German garters crossed athwart thy
frank
Stout Scottish legs, men watched thee snarl and
scowl,
And boys responsive with reverberate howl
Shrilled, hearing how to thee the springtime
stank
And as thine own soul all the world smelt
rank
And as thine own thoughts Liberty seemed foul.
Now, for all ill thoughts nursed and ill words
given
Not all condemned, not utterly forgiven,
Son of the storm and darkness, pass in
peace.
Peace upon earth thou knewest not: now, being
dead,
Rest, with nor curse nor blessing on thine head,
Where high-strung hate and strenuous envy
cease.

DICKENS

Chief in thy generation born of men
Whom English praise acclaimed as English-
born,
With eyes that matched the worldwide eyes
of morn
For gleam of tears or laughter, tenderest then
When thoughts of children warmed their light, or
when
Reverence of age with love and labour
worn,
Or godlike pity fired with godlike scorn,
Shot through them flame that winged thy swift
live pen:
Where stars and suns that we behold not burn,
Higher even than here, though highest was
here thy place,
Love sees thy spirit laugh and speak
and shine
With Shakespeare and the soft bright soul of
Sterne
And Fielding's kindest might and
Goldsmith's grace;
Scarce one more loved or worthier love
than thine.

ON LAMB'S SPECIMENS OF DRAMATIC POETS

I

If all the flowers of all the fields on earth
By wonder-working summer were made
one,
Its fragrance were not sweeter in the sun,
Its treasure-house of leaves were not more worth
Than those wherefrom thy light of musing mirth
Shone, till each leaf whereon thy pen would
run
Breathed life, and all its breath was benison.
Beloved beyond all names of English birth,
More dear than mightier memories; gentlest
name
That ever clothed itself with flower-sweet fame,
Or linked itself with loftiest names of old
By right and might of loving; I, that am
Less than the least of those within thy fold,
Give only thanks for them to thee, Charles
Lamb.

II

So many a year had borne its own bright bees
And slain them since thy honey-bees were
hived,
John Day, in cells of flower-sweet verse
contrived
So well with craft of moulding melodies,
Thy soul perchance in amaranth fields at ease

Thought not to hear the sound on earth
revived
Of summer music from the spring derived
When thy song sucked the flower of flowering
trees.
But thine was not the chance of every day:
Time, after many a darkling hour, grew
sunny,
And light between the clouds ere
sunset swam,
Laughing, and kissed their darkness all away,
When, touched and tasted and approved, thy
honey
Took subtler sweetness from the lips of
Lamb.

TO JOHN NICHOL

I

Friend of the dead, and friend of all my days
Even since they cast off boyhood, I salute
The song saluting friends whose songs are
mute
With full burnt-offerings of clear-spirited praise.
That since our old young years our several ways
Have led through fields diverse of flower
and fruit,
Yet no cross wind has once relaxed the root
We set long since beneath the sundawn's rays,
The root of trust whence towered the trusty tree,
Friendship—this only and duly might impel
My song to salutation of your own;
More even than praise of one unseen of me
And loved—the starry spirit of Dobell,
To mine by light and music only
known.

II

But more than this what moves me most of all
To leave not all unworded and unsped
The whole heart's greeting of my thanks
unsaid
Scarce needs this sign, that from my tongue
should fall
His name whom sorrow and reverent love recall,
The sign to friends on earth of that dear
head
Alive, which now long since untimely dead

The wan grey waters covered for a pall.
Their trustless reaches dense with tangling stems
Took never life more taintless of rebuke,
More pure and perfect, more serene
and kind,
Than when those clear eyes closed beneath the
Thames,
And made the now more hallowed name of
Luke
Memorial to us of morning left behind.

May 1881.

DYSTHANATOS

*Ad generem Cereris sine cæde et vulnere pauci
Descendunt reges, aut siccâ morte tyranni.*

By no dry death another king goes down
The way of kings. Yet may no free man's
voice,
For stern compassion and deep awe, rejoice
That one sign more is given against the crown,
That one more head those dark red waters drown
Which rise round thrones whose trembling
equipoise
Is propped on sand and bloodshed and such
toys
As human hearts that shrink at human frown.
The name writ red on Polish earth, the star
That was to outshine our England's in the far
East heaven of empire—where is one that
saith
Proud words now, prophesying of this White
Czar?
"In bloodless pangs few kings yield up their
breath,
Few tyrants perish by no violent death."

March 14, 1881.

[Transcriber's note: Please hover your mouse over the
Greek text below to see a transcription.]

EUONYMOS

εὖ μὲν ἢ τιμὴν ἐδίδου νικηφόρος ἀλκή
ἐκ νίκης ὄνομ' ἔσχε φόβου κέαρ αἰὲν ἄθικτος.

A year ago red wrath and keen despair
 Spake, and the sole word from their
 darkness sent
 Laid low the lord not all omnipotent
Who stood most like a god of all that were
As gods for pride of power, till fire and air
 Made earth of all his godhead. Lightning
 rent
 The heart of empire's lurid firmament,
And laid the mortal core of manhood bare.
But when the calm crowned head that all revere
For valour higher than that which casts out fear,
 Since fear came near it never, comes near
 death,
Blind murder cowers before it, knowing that here
 No braver soul drew bright and queenly
 breath
 Since England wept upon Elizabeth.

March 8, 1882.

ON THE RUSSIAN PERSECUTION OF THE JEWS

O son of man, by lying tongues adored,
By slaughterous hands of slaves with feet
red-shod
In carnage deep as ever Christian trod
Profaned with prayer and sacrifice abhorred
And incense from the trembling tyrant's horde,
Brute worshippers or wielders of the rod,
Most murderous even of all that call thee
God,
Most treacherous even that ever called thee Lord;
Face loved of little children long ago,
Head hated of the priests and rulers then,
If thou see this, or hear these hounds of
thine
Run ravening as the Gadarean swine,
Say, was not this thy Passion, to foreknow
In death's worst hour the works of Christian
men?

January 23, 1882.

BISMARCK AT CANOSSA

Not all disgraced, in that Italian town,
The imperial German cowered beneath
thine hand,
Alone indeed imperial Hildebrand,
And felt thy foot and Rome's, and felt her frown
And thine, more strong and sovereign than his
crown,
Though iron forged its blood-encrusted
band.
But now the princely wielder of his land,
For hatred's sake toward freedom, so bows down,
No strength is in the foot to spurn: its tread
Can bruise not now the proud submitted head:
But how much more abased, much lower
brought low,
And more intolerably humiliated,
The neck submissive of the prosperous foe,
Than his whom scorn saw shuddering in the
snow!

December 31, 1881.

QUIA NOMINOR LEO

I

What part is left thee, lion? Ravenous beast,
Which hadst the world for pasture, and for
scope
And compass of thine homicidal hope
The kingdom of the spirit of man, the feast
Of souls subdued from west to sunless east,
From blackening north to bloodred south
aslope,
All servile; earth for footcloth of the pope,
And heaven for chancel-ceiling of the priest;
Thou that hadst earth by right of rack and rod,
Thou that hadst Rome because thy name was
God,
And by thy creed's gift heaven wherein to
dwell;
Heaven laughs with all his light and might above
That earth has cast thee out of faith and love;
Thy part is but the hollow dream of hell.

II

The light of life has faded from thy cause,
High priest of heaven and hell and
purgatory:
Thy lips are loud with strains of oldworld
story,
But the red prey was rent out of thy paws
Long since: and they that dying brake down thy
laws
Have with the fires of death-enkindled glory

Put out the flame that faltered on thy hoary
High altars, waning with the world's applause.
This Italy was Dante's: Bruno died
Here: Campanella, too sublime for pride,
Endured thy God's worst here, and hence
went home.
And what art thou, that time's full tide should
shrink
For thy sake downward? What art thou, to think
Thy God shall give thee back for birthright
Rome?

January 1882.

THE CHANNEL TUNNEL

Not for less love, all glorious France, to thee,
 "Sweet enemy" called in days long since at
 end,
 Now found and hailed of England sweeter
 friend,
Bright sister of our freedom now, being free;
Not for less love or faith in friendship we
 Whose love burnt ever toward thee
 reprehend
 The vile vain greed whose pursy dreams
 portend
Between our shores suppression of the sea.
Not by dull toil of blind mechanic art
Shall these be linked for no man's force to part
 Nor length of years and changes to divide,
But union only of trust and loving heart
 And perfect faith in freedom strong to abide
 And spirit at one with spirit on either side.

April 3, 1882.

SIR WILLIAM GOMM

I

At threescore years and five aroused anew
 To rule in India, forth a soldier went
 On whose bright-fronted youth fierce war
 had spent
Its iron stress of storm, till glory grew
Full as the red sun waned on Waterloo.
 Landing, he met the word from England
 sent
 Which bade him yield up rule: and he,
 content,
Resigned it, as a mightier warrior's due;
And wrote as one rejoicing to record
That "from the first" his royal heart was lord
 Of its own pride or pain; that thought was
 none
Therein save this, that in her perilous strait
England, whose womb brings forth her sons so
great,
 Should choose to serve her first her
 mightiest son.

II

Glory beyond all flight of warlike fame
 Go with the warrior's memory who
 preferred
 To praise of men whereby men's hearts are
 stirred,
And acclamation of his own proud name
With blare of trumpet-blasts and sound and flame

Of pageant honour, and the titular word
That only wins men worship of the herd,
His country's sovereign good; who overcame
Pride, wrath, and hope of all high chance on
earth,
For this land's love that gave his great heart birth.
O nursling of the sea-winds and the sea,
Immortal England, goddess ocean-born,
What shall thy children fear, what strengths not
scorn,
While children of such mould are born to
thee?

SONNETS ON ENGLISH DRAMATIC POETS

(1590-1650)

I

CHRISTOPHER MARLOWE

Crowned, girdled, garbed and shod with light
and fire,

Son first-born of the morning, sovereign
star!

Soul nearest ours of all, that wert most far,
Most far off in the abysm of time, thy lyre
Hung highest above the dawn-enkindled quire
Where all ye sang together, all that are,
And all the starry songs behind thy car
Rang sequence, all our souls acclaim thee sire.

"If all the pens that ever poets held
Had fed the feeling of their masters'
thoughts,"
And as with rush of hurtling chariots
The flight of all their spirits were impelled
Toward one great end, thy glory—nay, not
then,
Not yet might'st thou be praised enough of
men.

II

WILLIAM SHAKESPEARE

Not if men's tongues and angels' all in one
 Spake, might the word be said that might
 speak Thee.
 Streams, winds, woods, flowers, fields,
 mountains, yea, the sea,
What power is in them all to praise the sun?
His praise is this,—he can be praised of none.
 Man, woman, child, praise God for him; but
 he
 Exults not to be worshipped, but to be.
He is; and, being, beholds his work well done.
All joy, all glory, all sorrow, all strength, all
mirth,
Are his: without him, day were night on earth.
 Time knows not his from time's own period.
All lutes, all harps, all viols, all flutes, all lyres,
Fall dumb before him ere one string suspires.
 All stars are angels; but the sun is God.

III

BEN JONSON

Broad-based, broad-fronted, bounteous,
multiform,

With many a valley impleached with ivy
and vine,

Wherein the springs of all the streams run
wine,

And many a crag full-faced against the storm,
The mountain where thy Muse's feet made warm
Those lawns that revelled with her dance
divine

Shines yet with fire as it was wont to shine
From tossing torches round the dance aswarm.

Nor less, high-stationed on the grey grave
heights,

High-thoughted seers with heaven's heart-
kindling lights

Hold converse: and the herd of meaner
things

Knows or by fiery scourge or fiery shaft
When wrath on thy broad brows has risen, and
laughed

Darkening thy soul with shadow of
thunderous wings.

IV

BEAUMONT AND FLETCHER

An hour ere sudden sunset fired the west,
 Arose two stars upon the pale deep east.
The hall of heaven was clear for night's high
 feast,
Yet was not yet day's fiery heart at rest.
Love leapt up from his mother's burning breast
 To see those warm twin lights, as day
 decreased,
 Wax wider, till when all the sun had ceased
As suns they shone from evening's kindled crest.
Across them and between, a quickening fire,
Flamed Venus, laughing with appeased desire.
 Their dawn, scarce lovelier for the gleam of
 tears,
Filled half the hollow shell 'twixt heaven and
earth
With sound like moonlight, mingling moan and
mirth,
 Which rings and glitters down the darkling
years.

V

PHILIP MASSINGER

Clouds here and there arisen an hour past noon
Chequered our English heaven with
lengthening bars
And shadow and sound of wheel-winged
thunder-cars

Assembling strength to put forth tempest soon,
When the clear still warm concord of thy tune
Rose under skies unscared by reddening
Mars

Yet, like a sound of silver speech of stars,
With full mild flame as of the mellowing moon.
Grave and great-hearted Massinger, thy face
High melancholy lights with loftier grace
Than gilds the brows of revel: sad and wise,
The spirit of thought that moved thy deeper song,
Sorrow serene in soft calm scorn of wrong,
Speaks patience yet from thy majestic eyes.

VI

JOHN FORD

Hew hard the marble from the mountain's heart
Where hardest night holds fast in iron
gloom
Gems brighter than an April dawn in bloom,
That his Memnonian likeness thence may start
Revealed, whose hand with high funereal art
Carved night, and chiselled shadow: be the
tomb
That speaks him famous graven with signs
of doom
Intrenched inevitably in lines athwart,
As on some thunder-blasted Titan's brow
His record of rebellion. Not the day
Shall strike forth music from so stern a
chord,
Touching this marble: darkness, none knows
how,
And stars impenetrable of midnight, may.
So looms the likeness of thy soul, John
Ford.

VII

JOHN WEBSTER

Thunder: the flesh quails, and the soul bows
down.

Night: east, west, south, and northward,
very night.

Star upon struggling star strives into sight,
Star after shuddering star the deep storms drown.

The very throne of night, her very crown,

A man lays hand on, and usurps her right.

Song from the highest of heaven's imperious
height

Shoots, as a fire to smite some towering town.

Rage, anguish, harrowing fear, heart-crazing
crime,

Make monstrous all the murderous face of Time

Shown in the spherul orbit of a glass

Revolving. Earth cries out from all her graves.

Frail, on frail rafts, across wide-wallowing
waves,

Shapes here and there of child and mother
pass.

VIII

THOMAS DECKER

Out of the depths of darkling life where sin
 Laughs piteously that sorrow should not
 know
 Her own ill name, nor woe be counted woe;
Where hate and craft and lust make drearier din
Than sounds through dreams that grief holds
revel in;
 What charm of joy-bells ringing, streams
 that flow,
 Winds that blow healing in each note they
 blow,
Is this that the outer darkness hears begin?

O sweetest heart of all thy time save one,
Star seen for love's sake nearest to the sun,
 Hung lamplike o'er a dense and doleful city,
Not Shakespeare's very spirit, howe'er more
great,
Than thine toward man was more compassionate,
 Nor gave Christ praise from lips more sweet
 with pity.

IX

THOMAS MIDDLETON

A wild moon riding high from cloud to cloud,
That sees and sees not, glimmering far
beneath,
Hell's children revel along the shuddering
heath

With dirge-like mirth and raiment like a shroud:
A worse fair face than witchcraft's, passion-
proud,

With brows blood-flecked behind their
bridal wreath

And lips that bade the assassin's sword find
sheath

Deep in the heart whereto love's heart was
vowed:

A game of close contentious crafts and creeds
Played till white England bring black Spain
to shame:

A son's bright sword and brighter soul, whose
deeds

High conscience lights for mother's love and
fame:

Pure gipsy flowers, and poisonous courtly
weeds:

Such tokens and such trophies crown thy
name.

X

THOMAS HEYWOOD

Tom, if they loved thee best who called thee
Tom,

What else may all men call thee, seeing thus
bright

Even yet the laughing and the weeping light
That still thy kind old eyes are kindled from?

Small care was thine to assail and overcome

Time and his child Oblivion: yet of right

Thy name has part with names of lordlier
might

For English love and homely sense of home,

Whose fragrance keeps thy small sweet bayleaf
young

And gives it place aloft among thy peers

Whence many a wreath once higher

strong Time has hurled:

And this thy praise is sweet on Shakespeare's
tongue—

"O good old man, how well in thee appears

The constant service of the antique
world!"

XI

GEORGE CHAPMAN

High priest of Homer, not elect in vain,
 Deep trumpets blow before thee, shawms
 behind
 Mix music with the rolling wheels that wind
Slow through the labouring triumph of thy train:
Fierce history, molten in thy forging brain,
 Takes form and fire and fashion from thy
 mind,
 Tormented and transmuted out of kind:
But howsoe'er thou shift thy strenuous strain,
Like Tailor^[1] smooth, like Fisher^[2] swollen, and
now
 Grim Yarrington^[3] scarce bloodier marked
 than thou,
 Then bluff as Mayne's^[4] or broad-mouthed
 Barry's^[5] glee;
Proud still with hoar predominance of brow
 And beard like foam swept off the broad
 blown sea,
 Where'er thou go, men's reverence goes
 with thee.

^[1] Author of *The Hog hath lost his Pearl*.

^[2] Author of *Fuimus Troes, or the True Trojans*.

^[3] Author of *Two Tragedies in One*.

^[4] Author of *The City Match*.

^[5] Author of *Ram-Alley, or Merry Tricks*.

XII

JOHN MARSTON

The bitterness of death and bitterer scorn
Breathes from the broad-leafed aloe-plant
whence thou
Wast fain to gather for thy bended brow
A chaplet by no gentler forehead worn.
Grief deep as hell, wrath hardly to be borne,
Ploughed up thy soul till round the
furrowing plough
The strange black soil foamed, as a black
beaked prow
Bids night-black waves foam where its track has
torn.
Too faint the phrase for thee that only saith
Scorn bitterer than the bitterness of death
Pervades the sullen splendour of thy soul,
Where hate and pain make war on force and
fraud
And all the strengths of tyrants; whence
unflawed
It keeps this noble heart of hatred whole.

XIII

JOHN DAY

Day was a full-blown flower in heaven, alive
With murmuring joy of bees and birds
aswarm,
When in the skies of song yet flushed and
warm
With music where all passion seems to strive
For utterance, all things bright and fierce to drive
Struggling along the splendour of the storm,
Day for an hour put off his fiery form,
And golden murmurs from a golden hive
Across the strong bright summer wind were
heard,
And laughter soft as smiles from girls at
play
And loud from lips of boys brow-bound
with May
Our mightiest age let fall its gentlest word,
When Song, in semblance of a sweet small bird,
Lit fluttering on the light swift hand of Day.

XIV

JAMES SHIRLEY

The dusk of day's decline was hard on dark
When evening trembled round thy
glowworm lamp
That shone across her shades and dewy
damp
A small clear beacon whose benignant spark
Was gracious yet for loiterers' eyes to mark,
Though changed the watchword of our
English camp
Since the outposts rang round Marlowe's
lion ramp,
When thy steed's pace went ambling round Hyde
Park.

And in the thickening twilight under thee
Walks Davenant, pensive in the paths where he,
The blithest throat that ever carolled love
In music made of morning's merriest heart,
Glad Suckling, stumbled from his seat above
And reeled on slippery roads of alien art.

XV

THE TRIBE OF BENJAMIN

Sons born of many a loyal Muse to Ben,
All true-begotten, warm with wine or ale,
Bright from the broad light of its presence,
hail!

Prince Randolph, nighest his throne of all his
men,
Being highest in spirit and heart who hailed him
then

King, nor might other spread so blithe a
sail:

Cartwright, a soul pent in with narrower
pale,

Praised of thy sire for manful might of pen:
Marmion, whose verse keeps alway keen and
fine

The perfume of their Apollonian wine
Who shared with that stout sire of all and
thee

The exuberant chalice of his echoing shrine:
Is not your praise writ broad in gold which
he

Inscribed, that all who praise his name
should see?

XVI

ANONYMOUS PLAYS:

"ARDEN OF FEVERSHAM"

Mother whose womb brought forth our man of
men,

Mother of Shakespeare, whom all time
acclaims

Queen therefore, sovereign queen of
English dames,

Throned higher than sat thy sonless empress
then,

Was it thy son's young passion-guided pen
Which drew, reflected from encircling
flames,

A figure marked by the earlier of thy names
Wife, and from all her wedded kinswomen
Marked by the sign of murderess? Pale and great,
Great in her grief and sin, but in her death
And anguish of her penitential breath

Greater than all her sin or sin-born fate,
She stands, the holocaust of dark desire,
Clothed round with song for ever as with
fire.

XVII

ANONYMOUS PLAYS

Ye too, dim watchfires of some darkling hour,
Whose fame forlorn time saves not nor
proclaims
For ever, but forgetfulness defames
And darkness and the shadow of death devour,
Lift up ye too your light, put forth your power,
Let the far twilight feel your soft small
flames
And smile, albeit night name not even their
names,
Ghost by ghost passing, flower blown down on
flower:
That sweet-tongued shadow, like a star's that
passed
Singing, and light was from its darkness cast
To paint the face of Painting fair with
praise:[1]
And that wherein forefigured smiles the pure
Fraternal face of Wordsworth's Elidure
Between two child-faced masks of merrier
days.[2]

[1] *Doctor Dodypol.*

[2] *Nobody and Somebody.*

XVIII

ANONYMOUS PLAYS

More yet and more, and yet we mark not all:
The Warning fain to bid fair women heed
Its hard brief note of deadly doom and deed;

[1]

The verse that strewed too thick with flowers the
hall

Whence Nero watched his fiery festival;[2]

That iron page wherein men's eyes who read
See, bruised and marred between two babes
that bleed,

A mad red-handed husband's martyr fall;[3]

The scene which crossed and streaked with mirth
the strife

Of Henry with his sons and witchlike wife;[4]

And that sweet pageant of the kindly fiend,

Who, seeing three friends in spirit and heart
made one,

Crowned with good hap the true-love wiles he
screened

In the pleached lanes of pleasant Edmonton.

[5]

[1] *A Warning for Fair Women.*

[2] *The Tragedy of Nero.*

[3] *A Yorkshire Tragedy.*

[4] *Look about you.*

[5] *The Merry Devil of Edmonton.*

XIX

THE MANY

I

Greene, garlanded with February's few flowers,

Ere March came in with Marlowe's

rapturous rage:

Peele, from whose hand the sweet white
locks of age

Took the mild chaplet woven of honoured hours:

Nash, laughing hard: Lodge, flushed from lyric
bowers:

And Lilly, a goldfinch in a twisted cage

Fed by some gay great lady's pettish page

Till short sweet songs gush clear like short spring
showers:

Kid, whose grim sport still gambolled over
graves:

And Chettle, in whose fresh funereal verse

Weeps Marian yet on Robin's wildwood

hearse:

Cooke, whose light boat of song one soft breath
saves,

Sighed from a maiden's amorous mouth

averse:

Live likewise ye: Time takes not you for slaves.

XX

THE MANY

II

Haughton, whose mirth gave woman all her will:
Field, bright and loud with laughing flower
and bird

And keen alternate notes of laud and gird:
Barnes, darkening once with Borgia's deeds the
quill

Which tuned the passion of Parthenophil:

Blithe burly Porter, broad and bold of word:
Wilkins, a voice with strenuous pity stirred:
Turk Mason: Brewer, whose tongue drops honey
still:

Rough Rowley, handling song with Esau's hand:
Light Nabbes: lean Sharpham, rank and raw
by turns,
But fragrant with a forethought once of
Burns:

Soft Davenport, sad-robed, but blithe and bland:
Brome, gipsy-led across the woodland
ferns:

Praise be with all, and place among our band.

XXI

EPILOGUE

Our mother, which wast twice, as history saith,
Found first among the nations: once, when
she

Who bore thine ensign saw the God in thee
Smite Spain, and bring forth Shakespeare: once,
when death

Shrank, and Rome's bloodhounds cowered, at
Milton's breath:

More than thy place, then first among the
free

More than that sovereign lordship of the sea
Bequeathed to Cromwell from Elizabeth,
More than thy fiery guiding-star, which Drake
Hailed, and the deep saw lit again for Blake,

More than all deeds wrought of thy strong
right hand,

This praise keeps most thy fame's memorial
strong

That thou wast head of all these streams of song,
And time bows down to thee as
Shakespeare's land.

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